Project: the Sargon Birth Legend → Hebrew

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Corpus: `../corpus.md` (read it, `../renderings.md` and `../translator-brief--kings.md` first).

Scope

All the lines in the base text: King's col. I 1–32 (K 3401 + Sm 2118 obverse, with K 4470 col. I and BM 47449) and
col. II 1–17 (K 4470 col. II) – 49 entries, in `annotated.rtl.md` (labels `I.1` … `II.17`).

Base text – and its limits (read this first)

- **The only open transliteration reachable on 2026-10-21 is King 1907** (vol. II pp. 87–96; public domain), which we
  transcribed by hand from the page images (`../../sources/King-1907--.../legend-of-sargon--King-1907-pp87-96.md`).
  It is a 1907 edition (rank 5 as an edition): its readings of the logograms and some signs are old, and it does not
  know K 7249 (CT 46 46), the fourth manuscript.
- **Checked against:** the eBL fragmentarium catalogue (no transliteration of K 3401+, K 4470 or K 7249; BM 47449 has
  only col. 4′, which belongs to another text – see below); the eBL dictionary for every word (per word); and the
  modern translation of ll. 1–14 by Westenholz 1997, quoted on the web (rank 3; brief quotations only).

- **Not reachable** (records: `../../sources/_records-only--Legends-of-kings/`): Westenholz 1997 (the current edition,
  © Eisenbrauns, not open access), Lewis 1980 (©; archive.org lending only and archive.org blocked), CT 13 42–43 and
  CT 46 46 (the copies; archive.org), CDLI P365306 / P365307 / P365303 (cdli.earth "temporarily offline", HTTP 503, all
  day 2026-10-21), Jiménez 2018 (BM 47449's edition).
- **Therefore:** every line is translated from King's transliteration as printed; where the modern reading is known to
  differ (from Westenholz's translation, or from the eBL dictionary's logograms), the apparatus says so and the Hebrew
  marks the point with `?` or `…`; nothing is filled from memory. **The user should get Westenholz 1997 (pp. 36–49)
  to check the whole text**, and K 7249 (lines Westenholz adds) is not translated (gap recorded).
- **BM 47449, rev. col. 4′** (eBL's only transliterated lines of the tablet: `gu₂-gal-li-ia`, `ana mar-ri-ia`,
  `A-MEŠ ul a-ṣa-pi` …) is edited by Jiménez 2018 among *disputation and fable extracts*: it is most likely not the
  Sargon legend and is not translated here.

Line numbering

King's col. I 1–32, col. II 1–17. Westenholz and Lewis number continuously (and add K 7249); their numbers are not
available to us. In King's col. I, ll. 2 and 3 are one line on K 3401 (divided by a mark).

The parallels that matter for the commentary

Exod 2:1–10 (the mother, the concealment, the basket, the bitumen, the river, drawn out, raised as a son); Exod 1:22;
2:16–19 (the drawing of water); Gen 10:8–12 (Akkad); Isa 20:1 (Sargon II); the royal boast (Isa 10:13–14; 37:24–25).

Open decisions

(Below, after the progress: "Open decisions (SB)".)

Progress

- 2026-10-21: drafted all 49 entries (`annotated.rtl.md`) from King's transliteration, with our normalization by
  the eBL dictionary (per word: *entu*, *quppu*, *šūru* II, *iṭṭû*, *peḫû*, *puzru*, *dālû*, *dalû*, *mārūtu*, *nukaribbūtu*, *râmu*, *akkullu*, *edēlu*, *ṭebû*, *rapādu* II, *ṣabītu*, *parû*, *nēšu*) and Westenholz's quoted
  translation of I.1–I.14 as the check.
- Review pass (a) fidelity: I.2 / I.5 *ēnetu* "high priestess" (King's "lowly" recorded); I.7 *ša lā elê'a* read with
  the suffix as subject ("from which I did not come up"); I.9 King's unread signs kept as `...` (Westenholz's "lowering
  his bucket" in the note only); I.16 / I.26 *edēlu* kept from King, italic (our alternative *ētelli* not checked);
  II.3 *rapādu* "roam" (eBL) for King's "couched".
- Review pass (b) consistency: the fixed strings `אַקִּי דולה־המים` (I.8–I.11), `לְבֵן`, `השליך`, `חֵמָר`, `קֻפָּה`, `שָׂם`, `גידל` (I.4, I.6, I.11) as renderings §4; *dannu* `החזק` (law corpus); *ṣalmāt qaqqadi* `שחורי הראש`;
  nabalkutu `חצה` (as Enmerkar's journey); *nakāru* `שינה`; *lū* + preterite = `אכן` throughout.
- Review pass (c) Hebrew: `שפת` (reserved) avoided in I.4 (`גדת`); `לְבֵן` vocalized (not "white"); `וארבע שנים [...]`
  (I.13) for the broken number.
- `verify SB`: OK (49 entries); `check_bible_quotes.py`: 0 problems.

Key findings (SB)

- **The bitumen is `חֵמָר`, the word of Exod 2:3** (I.6): the tablet has ESIR = *iṭṭû* (King's *iddî*), which by the
  flood corpus's rule is `חֵמָר` – the very word of `וַתַּחְמְרָה בַחֵמָר וּבַזָּפֶת` [equivalent]. **The *kupru* claim
  does not stand**: *kupru* (ESIR.UD.A, Gen 6:14 `כֹּפֶר`) is not in the text [absent]; it comes from the flood story.
- **The same verb, *šakānu* = `שָׂם`** (I.6 *iškunanni* ↔ `וַתָּשֶׂם בָּהּ אֶת הַיֶּלֶד`, Exod 2:3), and the same place
  "on the bank of the river" (I.4 *ina aḫi Puratti* ↔ `עַל שְׂפַת הַיְאֹר`) [equivalent].
- **`קֻפָּה` / `תֵּבָה`** [divergence]: Exod 2:3 uses two Egyptian words (`תֵּבַת גֹּמֶא`); the legend has the Akkadian
  quppu ša šūri "a basket of reed (bundles)" – the source of Mishnaic `קֻפָּה`.

- **Cast into the river** (l.7 *nadû* = השליך) ↔ Pharaoh's decree הַיְאֹרָה תַּשְׁלִיכֻהוּ (Exod 1:22) and the exposed
  infant of Ezek 16:5 [equivalent]; but Moses' mother does *not* cast him in – she places him at the bank [divergence].
- **Drawn out** (l.9 *ušēlânni* "lifted me up", Š of *elû*) ↔ כִּי מִן הַמַּיִם מְשִׁיתִהוּ (Exod 2:10) [divergence: no wordplay on a name; משה reserved].
- **Aqqi the water-drawer** (*dālû*, LÚ.A.BAL; King: *nâq mê* "irrigator") [cognate ↔ דָּלֹה דָלָה לָנוּ, Exod
  2:19]: the rescuer is a labourer, not a princess (Exod 2:5) [divergence]; **"he raised me as his son"** (*ana mārūti*
  … *urabbânni*) ↔ וַיִּגְדַּל הַיֶּלֶד … וַיְהִי לָהּ לְבֵן (Exod 2:10) [equivalent] – the legal language of adoption.
- **The high-priestess mother and the unknown father** (l.2, l.5): the birth is secret because an *entu* was not to
  bear children; Exod 2:1 begins with the father's house [divergence], though both mothers belong to the priestly
  sphere ("בַּת לֵוִי", our proposal); בֶּן אִשָּׁה זוֹנָה (Judg 11:1) – the leader of blemished birth.
- **Gardener → king by Ištar's love** (l.11–l.13) ↔ מִן הַנָּוֶה מֵאַחַר הַצֹּאן לִהְיוֹת נָגִיד (2 Sam 7:8) [equivalent]; תַּעֲשֶׂה מְלוּכָה (1 Kgs 21:7) = *šarrūta epēšu* [equivalent]; a goddess's love as the source of
  kingship has no biblical counterpart [absent].
- **The boast list and the challenge to the next king** (l.14–l.31): the mountains destroyed with copper axes, the
  Sealand circled three times ↔ the Assyrian boast quoted by Isaiah (Isa 37:24; 10:15) and the circuits of Jericho
  (Josh 6:15); "whatever king shall rise after me" ↔ מָה הָאָדָם שֶׁיָּבוֹא אַחֲרֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ (Eccl 2:12).
- **The ancient mind:** a founder-king whose legitimacy is a story of shame turned into election; the river as the
  agent that judges and carries; adoption as a legal act; the royal inscription as a dare to posterity.

Open decisions (SB)

1. l.2 / l.5 *e-ni-tum*: *ēnetu* "high priestess" (followed) or King's *enītu* "lowly"?
2. l.7 *ša lā elê'a*: "from which I did not come up" (followed; Westenholz) or "which did not rise over me" (King)?
3. l.9: King's *ḫi-ib-[..]-li-[..]* vs Westenholz's "when lowering his bucket" – the signs need the modern edition.
4. l.16 / l.26: *edēlu* "bolt" (King) or a form of *elû* "go up" (our unverified proposal)?
5. Col. II: part of the legend or another text on K 4470? (Westenholz needed.)

6. **The whole text must be checked against Westenholz 1997 (pp. 36–49) and K 7249** before publication.

Proposals for the corpus renderings (SB)

- *entu* / *ēnetu* אֵנְתּוּ (law corpus); *puzru* סתר; *quppu ša šūri* קֻפָּה של קנים; *iṭṭû* חֵמָר; *peḫû* אטם; *bābu* (of a box) פתח; *nadû* השליך; *dālû* דולה־המים; *ana mārūti* לְבֶן; *nukaribbūtu* גַּנָּנוּת; *šarrūta epēšu* מלכות עשה; *akkullu* קרדום; *erû* נחושת; *lamû* סבב; *māt tiāmti* ארץ הים; *rapādu* שוטט; *purīmu* פרא; *parû* פרד; *ṣabītu* צבייה; *nēšu* אריה; *ākilu* אוכל.

Parallels index (SB)

Line	Source	Hebrew rendering	Bible	Tag	Comment
I.1	Šarru-ukîn … šar A-ga-de	סרגון … מלך אכד	סַרְגּוֹן מֶלֶךְ אַשּׁוּר (ישעיהו כ:א)	cognate	The same name; Sargon II, under whom the legend was probably written.
I.2	a-bi ul i-di	אבי – לא ידעתי	וַיֵּלֶךְ אִישׁ מִבֵּית לֵוִי; וַיִּקַּח אֶת בַּת לֵוִי (שמות ב:א)	divergence	Moses' story starts with the father; Sargon's has none.
I.2	um-mi e-ni-tum	אמי – אנתו	וְהוּא בֶּן אִשָּׁה זוֹנָה (שופטים יא:א)	equivalent	A leader of blemished birth.
I.4	ina a-ḫi {nâru}Puratti šak-nu	על גדת נהר פרת שׂוּמָה	וַתָּשֶׂם בַּסּוּף עַל שְׂפַת הַיְאֹר (שמות ב:ג)	equivalent	The river bank; *šakānu* = שָׂם.
I.5	i-ra-an-ni … ina pu-uz-ri u-lid-an-ni	הרתני … בסתר ילדתני	וַתַּהַר הָאִשָּׁה וַתֵּלֶד בֵּן; וַתֵּרֶא אֹתוֹ כִּי טוֹב הוּא וַתִּצְפְּנֵהוּ שְׁלֹשָׁה יְרָחִים (שמות ב:ב)	equivalent	Conception, birth, concealment.
I.6	i-na iddî bâbi-ia ip-ḫi	בחמר את פתחי אטמה	וַתַּחְמְרָה בַחֵמָר וּבַזָּפֶת (שמות ב:ג)	equivalent	ESIR = *iṭṭû* = חֵמָר: the same word.
I.6	iš-kun-an-ni i-na ḳup-pi ša šu-ri	שׂמתני בקֻפָּה של קנים	וַתִּקַּח לוֹ תֵּבַת גֹּמֶא (שמות ב:ג)	divergence	Egyptian תֵּבַת גֹּמֶא vs Akkadian *quppu ša šūri*; the verb וַתָּשֶׂם = *iškunanni*.
I.6	iddî (ESIR)	חמר	וְכָפַרְתָּ אֹתָהּ מִבַּיִת וּמִחוּץ בַּכֹּפֶר (בראשית ו:יד)	absent	*kupru* (ESIR.UD.A) is not in the text.

Line	Source	Hebrew rendering	Bible	Tag	Comment
I.7	id-dan-ni a-na [nâ]ri	השליכתני אל הנהר	כָּל הַבֵּן הַיִּלּוֹד הַיְאֹרָה תַּשְׁלִיכֻהוּ (שמות א:כב)	equivalent	*nadû* = השליך.
I.7	id-dan-ni	השליכתני	וַתַּשְׁלְכִי אֶל פְּנֵי הַשָּׂדֶה בְּגֹעַל נַפְשֵׁךְ בְּיוֹם הֻלֶּדֶת אֹתָךְ (יחזקאל טז:ה)	equivalent	The exposed newborn.
I.8	{m}Ak-ki {amêlu}nâḳ-mê	אַקִּי דולה־המים	וְגַם דָּלֹה דָּלָה לָנוּ וַיַּשְׁקְ אֶת הַצֹּאן (שמות ב:יט)	cognate	*dālû* ~ דָּלָה.
I.8	ana eli {m}Ak-ki ... u-bil-an-ni	אל אקי ... הובילני	וַתֵּרֶד בַּת פַּרְעֹה לִרְחֹץ עַל הַיְאֹר (שמות ב:ה)	divergence	The finder: a labourer, not a princess.
I.9	lu-u u-še-la-an-ni	אכן העלני	כִּי מִן הַמַּיִם מְשִׁיתִהוּ (שמות ב:י)	divergence	"Lifted up" (*elû* Š), no name etymology.
I.10	a-na ma-ru-ti-šu ... u-rab-ban-ni	לְבֵן לו ... גידלני	וַיִּגְדַּל הַיֶּלֶד וַתְּבִאֵהוּ לְבַת פַּרְעֹה וַיְהִי לָהּ לְבֵן (שמות ב:י)	equivalent	Adoption formula.
I.11	a-na {amêlu}...-ti-šu lu-u iš-kun-an-ni	לגננות שלו – אכן שׂמני	אֲנִי לְקַחְתִּיךְ מִן הַנָּוֶה מֵאַחַר הַצֹּאן לִהְיוֹת נָגִיד (שמואל ב ז:ח)	equivalent	From humble work to rule.
I.12	{ilu}lš-tar lu-u i-ra-man-ni-ma	אשתר אכן אהבתני	דּוֹדִי יָרַד לְגַנּוֹ לַעֲרֻגוֹת הַבֹּשֶׂם (שיר השירים ו:ב)	equivalent	Love and the garden.
I.12	{ilu}lš-tar lu-u i-ra-man-ni-ma	אשתר אכן אהבתני	וַיהוָה אֲהֵבוֹ (שמואל ב יב:כד)	absent	No goddess's love makes a king in the Bible.

Line	Source	Hebrew rendering	Bible	Tag	Comment
I.13	šarru-u-ta lu-u e-pu-uš	מלכות אכן עשיתי	אַתָּה עַתָּה תַּעֲשֶׂה מְלוּכָה עַל יִשְׂרָאֵל (מלכים א כא:ז)	equivalent	"To do kingship".
I.15	šadê dannûti ina aḳ-ḳul-la-te ša erû lu-u ub-bit	הרים חזקים – בקרדומות נחושת – אכן ניתצתי	אֲנִי עָלִיתִי מְרוֹם הָרִים יָרַכְתֵּי לְבָנוֹן (ישעיהו לז:כד)	equivalent	The royal boast of conquering mountains.
I.15	aḳ-ḳul-la-te	בקרדומות	הֲיִתְפָּאֵר הַגַּרְזֶן עַל הַחֹצֵב בּוֹ (ישעיהו י:טו)	divergence	The prophet's answer to the boast.
I.18	ma-ti ti-amat lu-u al-ma-a III šanîtu	את ארץ הים – אכן סבבתי שלוש פעמים	רַק בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא סָבְבוּ אֶת הָעִיר שָׁבַע פְּעָמִים (יהושע ו:טו)	equivalent	Circling a fixed number of times.
I.22	mannu šarru ša i-la-a arki-ia	כל מלך אשר יעלה אחרי	כִּי מָה הָאָדָם שֶׁיָּבוֹא אַחֲרֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ (קהלת ב:יב)	equivalent	The king who comes after.
II.4	ṣabîtu	צבייה	כְּשֶׁנֵי עֳפָרִים תְּאוֹמֵי צְבִיָּה (שיר השירים ד:ה)	cognate	*ṣabītu* ~ צְבִיָּה.
II.8	pur[imu]	פרא	וְהוּא יִהְיֶה פֶּרֶא אָדָם (בראשית טז:יב)	cognate	*purīmu* ~ פֶּרֶא.
II.14	nêšu a-ki-lu	אריה אוכל	מֵהָאֹכֵל יָצָא מַאֲכָל וּמֵעַז יָצָא מָתוֹק (שופטים יד:יד)	equivalent	The lion as "the eater".